

A Practical Study of PHILIPPIANS

THE GOAL OF CHRISTIAN LIVING

“Important Keys to Successful, Fulfilled Living”

Goal Number Six – The Things of Christ – Philippians 2:19-24

Revelation 22:12

And behold I come quickly and my reward is with me, to give every man, according as his work shall be.

How lethargic we've become with regard to the coming of Christ. We ought to be intensely excited with every day that passes the promise of that fulfillment draws another day closer.

In our cynical unbelief, because it's been 2,000 years, we feel like we have forever. That's the way the prophetic scripture has described the attitude and the hearts of individuals even in the last days.

Here's a very sobering piece of poetry written by Martha Snell Nickerson about the Judgment Seat of Christ and the responsibility as a believer for the days that we live as Christians:

HIS PLAN FOR ME

When I stand at the judgment seat of Christ
And He shows me His plan for me,
The Plan of my life as it might have been
Had He had His way, and I see

How I blocked Him here, and I checked Him there,
And I would not yield my will—
Will there be grief in my Savior's eyes,
Grief, though He loves me still?

He would have me rich, and I stand there poor,
Stripped of all but His grace,
While memory runs like a hunted thing
Down the paths I cannot retrace.

Then my desolate heart will well-nigh break
With the tears that I cannot shed;
I shall cover my face with my empty hands,
I shall bow my uncrowned head.

Lord of the years that are left to me,
I give them to Thy hand;
Take me and break me, mould me to
The pattern Thou hast planned!

[http://www.cavaliersonly.com/poetry by christian poets of the past/poetry by martha snell nicholson](http://www.cavaliersonly.com/poetry%20by%20christian%20poets%20of%20the%20past/poetry%20by%20martha%20snell%20nicholson) (accessed 10.05.18)

The major goal is Christlikeness. All these things are secondary and are things we can expect—things that ought to be a part of our life. We ought to be characterized by love. We ought to be living for His glory. We ought to be prepared, knowing we're going to suffer—it's inevitable. We're predestined to have that happen to us.

We need to learn how to think His thoughts instead of ours. Our lives ought to be ordered to that finish line—the Day of Christ.

We've titled this particular goal:

THE THINGS OF CHRIST.

Each one of these goals comes out of a little phrase in the verses.

Whereas we talked about Jesus Christ in the MIND OF CHRIST, and we talked about Paul when he said:

Philippians 2:17

... if I am being poured out as a drink offering upon the sacrifice and service of your faith, I joy and rejoice with you all.

Now we turn to Timothy when we come to this particular study.

How concerned are you about the things of Christ?

Do you really know what turns the Lord on?

Do you really know as a believer what brings Him real joy?

Have you talked to Him enough to really know what's on His heart?

We get so bogged down in just living OUR lives, taking care of OUR kids and going to OUR work and making OUR money and living in OUR house and driving OUR cars and doing OUR thing. We're just Christians in name. We don't even know, we don't even have the foggiest notion what is on the heart of Jesus Christ and what it is He wants from us.

Don't start doing a whole bunch of self-analysis and trying to figure out what makes you tick and all of that. We should spend more time with the Lord.

Erma Bombeck in her book *Aunt Erma's Cope Book* she talks about this. She says:

(Aunt Erma's Cope Book by Erma Bombeck)

Our forefathers didn't know what they were laying on us when they penned the Declaration of Independence. Life and liberty were pieces of cake compared to the pursuit of happiness. I have lived this book for over a year and never knew how

miserable I was until I tried to find out why I was happy. Oh, I knew I was bored, depressed, neurotic, inhibited, and unfulfilled; but I figured, no one is perfect. During the last year, I have come to grips with mid-life, found inner peace, fought outer flab, interpreted my fantasies, examined my motives for buying, dissected my marriage, charted my astrological stars and become my best and only friend. I have brought order to my life, meditated, given up guilt, adjusted to the new morality, and spent every living hour understanding me, interpreting me, and loving me. And you know what? I'm bored to death with me. If I never hear another word about me, it'll be too soon. I have no more curiosity about myself, no more drive to make me a better person. No more patience to find out what I am feeling. If I never see the words input, concept, feedback, or bottom line, it will be alright with me. If I ever say the words "share with you," or "at this point of time in my life," I hope my saliva runs dry. After a year of reading 62 self-help books and articles, I have discovered something very interesting. You don't find happiness. It finds you.

One of my friends said, "You're going through your mid-life crisis?" "It sounds redundant," I said. "Believe me," said Nancy, "I know where you're coming from. You feel used up, unfulfilled, unappreciated. Your life is in the Twilight Zone, and you live in fear; fear that your children are writing a sequent to *Mommy, Dearest*; fear of dying after you've just eaten a crummy, tasteless salad with a low-calorie dressing, the fear of going to a partner-swapping party and nobody wants to swap with you.

After a year of research, it became apparent to me, the only how-to book I have enough expertise to write was: *How*

To Get From Monday to Friday in 12 Days. In her infinite wisdom my mother offered yet another observation on my months of self-examination, devotion to improvement and quest for happiness. She said, “I’ll be glad when you hit menopause. It’ll take your mind off your problems.”
(source unknown)

That’s what people are doing. They’re chasing all around, reading this trash and trying to find happiness. Analyzing their motives and their friends and whole past life history to explain why they’re such nerds now. We have it in the Scripture that if we’re consumed with the things of Jesus Christ and what pleases His heart, we will be so happy and so fulfilled.

Maybe the reason we don’t have much happiness in our life right now is we’re just all bogged down in our things because that’s the majority, according to Paul.

Could we just say, “Lord, I’m available. Teach me what’s on Your heart. Teach me what You really want, what You desire of us. What is Your purpose and Your program? Lord, get me excited about what You are trying to do in this generation and why I am living.”

We often face many PICKY Christians. They PICK where they want to be involved. They PICK where they want to obey. And they PICK where they’ll spend their time instead of an all-out, total and complete commitment.

We read these words:

Luke 14:28ff

Which one of you, when he wants to build a tower, does not first sit down and calculate the cost to see if he had enough to complete it? Otherwise, when he has laid a foundation and is not able to finish, all who observe it begin to ridicule him saying, "This man began to build and was not able to finish." Or what king, when he sets out to meet another king in battle will not first sit down and take counsel whether he is strong enough with ten thousand men to encounter the one coming against him with twenty thousand; or else while the other is still far away, he sends a delegation and asks for terms of peace. So therefore no one of you can be my disciple who does not give up all of his possessions. Therefore salt is good, but even if salt has become tasteless, with what will it be seasoned? It is useless either for the soil or for the manure pile. It is thrown out. And he who has ears let him here.

It's time for us to sit down and scrutinize not only what are the things of Christ, but am I willing to pay the price to be God's man and God's woman?

Matthew 6:24

No man can serve two masters, for either he will hate the one and love the other, or he will hold to the one and despise the other. You cannot serve God and mammon.

It's time to make some choices. How concerned are you about making it one of your goals to find out what is on the heart of God? What is it that He longs to bring about in your life besides making you into the image of Christ? How does He want to use you?

Let's walk through the verses. We have just a few and they'll be easy to follow.

v. 19 But I am hoping in the Lord Jesus to send Timothy to you quickly, in order that I also may be of good cheer having come to know the things concerning you.

“But I am hoping in the Lord Jesus to send Timothy to you quickly, in order that I also may be of good cheer having come to know the things concerning you.”

Earlier he gave a command:

Philippians 2:5

Let this mind be in you which was also in Christ Jesus,

Paul, when he gives a command like that, a lot of times will flesh it out in people so we can really see what it looks like.

The very first person that he fleshes it out in is Jesus Christ Himself, Who emptied Himself taking the form of a servant.

That's the way the mind of Christ looks—SERVANTHOOD.

We see it in SACRIFICE in Paul. “If my life’s poured out, it’s no big deal” he says. “For your faith, I’m glad to be spent.”

Now when we come to Timothy, Timothy has spent enough time in the presence of God to know that God delights in sacrificial servanthood.

Timothy is a guy who will go anywhere to do anything at any price. He stops at nothing. He just follows as a perfect disciple in the footsteps of the apostle Paul.

“I am now hoping quickly, to send this young man Timothy to you.”

Timothy really adopted Paul when Paul came to Lystra. When he saw what Paul went through, Paul had a chance to share with him and then Timothy traveled with him after that. Paul loved him so much he wrote his last two letters under divine inspiration to this young man. He was kind of shy, timid and kind of backward. He never really had a male image in his life until Paul came along.

Paul saw real possibilities in him and he hoped that he could send him to him. Now look what he says about him. This is so great.

He stands out. He's not going down the same track that everybody else is traveling.

v. 20 For I am having no one else of kindred spirit who will genuinely be concerned about the things concerning you.

“For I am having no one else of kindred spirit who genuinely will be concerned about the things concerning you.”

“I want to tell you folks in Philippi that in all my ministerial team, I don't have anybody like Timothy. You know, there's just something about Timothy. When you meet him you know he really cares and you know he's really listening to you. And he knows that he wants to do something about what he hears.”

Sometimes when we're talking to someone we can tell if they're really listening. You know when they are just waiting to start talking.

Paul could tell that about Timothy. He could tell when you walked up, took him by the hand, that he was going to listen to what you had to say. And he was going to ask some lead questions and he was going to let you know that he really loved you and cared about you.

How did he get that? The Lord Jesus put that in him. The apostle Paul commends him for that.

“I don’t have anybody with a kindred spirit who is willing to be concerned about the things concerning you.”

What do we have so far about the MIND OF CHRIST? We have Jesus emptying Himself. We have Paul throwing himself on the altar for the faith of others.

We have Timothy who can look right at you and say, “Man I love you and your burdens are my burdens and your problems are mine. And I want to be involved in doing what I can do.”

When we think of Timothy we think of the GOOD SAMARITAN. Two other guys that were religious came down the road that day—a priest and a Levite. Both of them have the same excuse. They had to get going. Neither one of them had time to stop. But when it came to the Samaritan, he had time to stop, he cared to get involved, and he did something about the situation. He had compassion.

Paul says, “Timothy’s different! He’s a man characterized by a willingness to go anywhere, to anyone, to do anything at any cost. He displays the mind of Christ in his selfless spirit. All he wants to do is to serve and to minister.”

Timothy really does have a servant’s heart; a desire to work behind the scenes and to please.

“...no one who will be genuinely concerned about the things concerning you.”

A. B. Simpson was the founder of the Christian Missionary Alliance. He had a guest one night staying in his home. And the guest rose earlier than they'd anticipated and he went in and happened to walk past the study and here was A. B. Simpson with his arms around the globe and tears running down his cheeks.
(source unknown)

That's it. That's a man who knows the things of Christ; who knows the love of a lost and dying world, and who is pained, burdened over sheep who have no shepherd, for people who have not become saved.

It is in the book of Jeremiah we read:

Jeremiah 8:20

The summer has ended and we are not saved.

Yes, that's the heart-cry—that's the major concern.

What's the difference between Timothy and everybody else?

v. 21 For they all are seeking their own things, not the things of Christ Jesus.

“For they all are seeking their own things, not the things of Christ Jesus.”

There is our KEY VERSE.

Timothy is an example of what it is to be a servant, to demonstrate the MIND OF CHRIST. But they're few and far between. Most people "...all are seeking their own things..."

Naturally we immediately want definition. What does it mean if we're characterized as a person who's more concerned about our own things than about the things of others?

Here are several P's for homiletical purposes:

POWER,

PRESTIGE,

POSITION,

PLEASURE,

POSSESSIONS.

As we examine your heart, what is the number one priority and concern right now? The thing that is overwhelming? What is it?

Does that have anything to do with the things of Christ? Or does it have something to do with the here and now?

2 Timothy 4:10

Demas, having loved this present world, deserted me and has gone to Thessalonica.

What happened to Demas? He went to one of his class reunions in Thessalonica. Several of the guys in his class were driving up in sports cars, several of them have been quite successful, dressed in real nice clothes, and they asked Demas what he'd been doing.

“Oh I’ve been bumping around with this itinerant preacher; persecuted and knocked around in every place we’ve ever gone. Eating dust on the dirty roads as we go from city to city and nobody likes us.”

Well his classmates said, “Hey man, I’ve really hit pay dirt here in Thessalonica. Why don’t you come on over and join me?”

That was just good enough for Demas. He bought the whole life. Now he sleeps in silk pajamas, lives in the penthouse, and has a couple of camels in the garage. He really has it made, doesn’t he? But in view of eternity he sold his soul because all those things are going to pass away.

Eventually we have to sort all that stuff out in our Christian life. And just thinking about it isn’t going to make it go away, because we’re losing. We don’t have a long time before we’re going to have to meet Him. It’s good as soon as possible to begin to discover what it is that really, really pleases the heart

of God and are the things that ought to concern us.

Most of these people:

I is their God and

SELF is their goal, and

ME, ME, ME is their slogan.

That's the way they live.

There are two basic REASONS why people aren't willing to sell out completely to Jesus Christ:

1. They're too concerned about themselves.
2. They're too little concerned about the things of Christ.

Their major priority is their own things. They're not willing to bear the cross. They're not willing to pay the price.

The top priority in Timothy's life are the THINGS OF GOD. That's our goal. That's our objective.

When all of these other goals begin to take flesh and form in our lives, this one just kind of rears its head.

Are we locked in to the purpose of God? Are we consumed and

using the time that we have left investing it wisely with the things that God would want us to do with our time? It's the battle of the world vs. the things of Christ.

Now there's a great old hymn that fits well here:

*You have longed for sweet peace and for faith to increase,
Oh and you've earnestly, fervently prayed,
But you cannot have rest or be perfectly blessed,
Until all on the altar is laid.*

*Is your all on the altar of sacrifice laid?
Your heart does the Spirit control?
You can only be blest, and have peace and sweet rest,
As you yield Him your body and soul.*

(source unknown)

When we read something like this, we really look forward to meeting Timothy. He must have been a fantastic individual.

v. 22 But you are knowing the proof of him, that as a child to a father, he served with me for the gospel.

“You are knowing the proof of him, that as a child to a father, he served with me for the gospel.”

He already has his credentials as a servant. He worked with the apostle Paul and became his dearly beloved son.

So far in these first two chapters, when we have talked about

ministry, when we have talked about the things that are concerning the heart of God, there are some words back there that we kind of passed over and we didn't think about.

What are the words that he has used so far to describe ministry?

SERVED,

SACRIFICE,

SHINING,

POURED OUT,

STRUGGLE,

SUFFERING.

Now you don't want to sign up for that, do you?

How many of us want to really get serious about the things of Christ? How many of us are going to say, "I just can't wait to sign up"?

That runs contrary doesn't it? Because we want to get just close enough to get warm fuzzies but we don't want to get close enough to become a fanatic or get consumed and become someone who really can be used by God.

What we're trying to do here is to see in young Timothy some of the things that made him the man he was. They were:

LOVE,

GLORY,

SUFFERING,

MIND,

THE DAY OF CHRIST, and

he's consumed with THE THINGS OF CHRIST.

That's a man locked in with a purpose that's going to touch anybody that he comes in contact with.

v. 23 This one therefore I am hoping to send immediately, as soon as I see how things go with me;

“This one therefore I am hoping to send immediately, as soon as I see how things go with me;”

“I need him around here so much, I hate to let him go but for your sake I hope pretty quickly I can turn him loose and get him on up there.”

v. 24 but I have a certainty in the Lord that I also myself shall come shortly.

“but I have a certainty in the Lord that I also myself shall come shortly.”

Isn't that great? Where is he? He's sitting in prison.

Has he been worried about whether he's going to get out or not?

Back in chapter 1 he said he had a “desire to depart and be with Christ, which was far better” and he thought he might be throwing it in.

Have you ever done that? Have you ever gone through the experience of praying over something, just agonizing over it, and you just kept praying and praying and praying? And then all of a sudden, there comes a sweeping sense of peace and relief that the answer was there? Ever done that?

Sometimes as we pray we're going to have a certainty but then it's going to be different than we thought.

Jeremiah 33:3

Call unto me and I will answer thee so that great and mighty things which thou knowest not.

Jeremiah 32:27

Behold I'm the Lord God of all flesh. Is anything too hard for Me?

Psalm 50:15

Call upon Me in the day of trouble and I will deliver thee and thou shalt glorify Me.

When we take our wishes and our will out of it, then it will be totally consistent with what the Lord has to say. It's exactly on target.

Paul says:

“I have a certainty now.”

Obviously he's been spending some time in prayer before he wrote the rest of chapter 2.

And he says, “I'm going to send Timothy but I have a certainty that I am going to get to come too and to be with you.”

Remember he says:

Philippians 1:19

I am knowing that this shall issue in deliverance for me through your petition and support and in Spirit of Jesus Christ.

“As you pray and as I am praying, there is a certainty that the answer is going to come and I am going to have a chance to see you beloved Philippians back there in the northern section of Macedonia. I’m looking forward to that.”

What are the lessons we got out of the study?

Lesson #1: It is the servant heart that delights the heart of God.

Lesson #2: Timothy’s availability to the Lord’s service was unconditional.

Lesson #3: Timothy is genuinely concerned for the things of others.

Lesson #4: The things of Christ involve: sacrifice, service, spending ourselves, and a willingness to shed our blood.

Lesson #5: Have you ever experienced a certainty in the Lord that He was going to do some specific thing in your life?

Have you ever experienced a certainty in the Lord that He’s going to do something specific in your life?

For Abraham and Sarah it was 25 years but then God fulfilled that goal.

The things of Christ—how concerned are you about the things

that concern the heart of God?

Father, thank You for this young man that has stepped off of the page of Scripture to refresh us, to instruct us. Lord, our lives pale in shallowness when we see such sacrificial servanthood spelled out in the lives of these three men we've looked at so far. Thank You that the Son of God didn't just sit on His throne and enjoy His glory but His longing for a relationship with us motivated Him to move in and make a miracle happen by sacrificing Himself. Thank You for Paul, incredible individual, suffering—giving himself unselfishly to others. And thank You for Timothy and what we've seen in his life. Lord, we pray that we will really become uncomfortable and that some of these goals will begin to really gnaw us on the inside—that we will own-up to the shallow love that we express, we'll own-up to our own self-glory instead of being consumed with Yours. We will tell You that we don't like to suffer, we want to be comfortable. We'll tell You that we prefer our thoughts to Yours. That we want to live for here and now instead of in view of the day of Christ, and that we want to do our things rather than Yours. And then to realize how silly that is and make it all right with You, giving ourselves fully and completely and laying it all on the altar. In Jesus' name we pray. Amen.

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“Important Keys to Successful, Fulfilled Living”

GOAL NUMBER SIX – THE THINGS OF CHRIST – PHILIPPIANS 2:19-24

KEY VERSE 2:21

v. 19 But I am hoping in the Lord Jesus to send Timothy to you quickly, in order that I also may be of good cheer having come to know the things concerning you.

v. 20 For I am having no one else of kindred spirit who will genuinely be concerned about the things concerning you.

v. 21 For they all are seeking their own things, not the things of Christ Jesus.

v. 22 But you are knowing the proof of him, that as a child to a father, he served with me for the gospel.

v. 23 This one therefore I am hoping to send immediately, as soon as I see how things go with me;

v. 24 but I have a certainty in the Lord that I also myself shall come shortly.

NOTES

QUESTIONS:

1. Read Philippians 2:19-24 and in your own words pull out the main thought of this passage.

2. Who does Paul want to send to Philippi, and why, according to verse 19?

3. From these verses, describe Timothy in your own words.

4. What made Timothy different, according to verse 21?

5. What did Timothy do, according to verse 22?

6. How is your life different than Timothy's?

7. How is your life the same as Timothy's?

8. What does Paul hope to do, according to verse 24?

9. Which verse in the study has meant the most to you?

10. What lesson have you learned from this study?

LESSONS FROM THE PASSAGE:

What are some of the lessons we can learn from this particular study?

LESSON #1: It is the servant heart that delights the heart of God.

LESSON #2: Timothy's availability to the Lord's service was unconditional.

LESSON #3: Timothy is genuinely concerned for the things of others.

LESSON #4: The things of Christ involve: sacrifice, service, spending ourselves, and a willingness to shed our blood.

LESSON #5: Have you ever experienced a certainty in the Lord that He was going to do some specific thing in your life?